

FRESH FOR UNLOCK

If it's your first sentence, you go to the classification wing.

Everyone locked down twenty out of twenty-four hours. Unlocked at 0630 for showers and breakfast—you've got an hour to wash, eat, fill your thermos if you have one, interact with whoever else is awake. Then back to your cell.

Lunch comes to you at noon.

1300 to 1600 is yard time—but you choose. If you go out, you stay out until time's up. If you stay in, you stay in. Door locked either way.

Dinner at 1700. Eat in your cell.

Repeat.

The intake process was familiar by then. Strip search. Photos. Fingerprints. Sign away whatever personal property you walked in with.

But now I was given a number.

It was on all the uniform they issued. On the card outside my cell. On every piece of paper that would follow me through the system.

Last name and a number.

That's who I was to the staff.

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They celled me up with a guy in his late twenties.

Drunk driving charges. Never been in trouble with the law otherwise—a civilian who'd made one bad decision and found himself somewhere he had no framework for understanding.

Tall. Lanky. Petrified of the place.

He barely left his cell. Stayed on his bunk—bottom one was his—and watched the hours pass like he was waiting for someone to tell him it was all a mistake.

First thing I did that night was ask for razors.

Shaved my head clean. Fresh for unlock in the morning.

I wanted to make a statement. Of who I was. What I stood for. Ensure there was no confusion.

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First unlock.

I stepped out of the cell with a fresh head and prison blues. The wing was already moving—blokes shuffling to showers, queuing for breakfast, filling thermoses, sizing each other up.

I spotted a couple of whiteboys across the space.

Silent recognition. A nod that said *I see you* without saying anything at all. The unspoken politics of incarceration—you find your people, you acknowledge the connection, you don't make a big thing of it.

I went to the yard first chance I got.

Wasn't about to be seen as weak or afraid of anything. Tried to get my celly to come with me—fresh air, movement, break up the monotony—but he wasn't keen. Wouldn't even consider it.

This concerned me.

If he was seen as weak, and I was celled up with him, that weakness could transfer by proxy. Association is currency in there. The wrong association costs you.

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A couple of days went by. Nothing exciting.

There were some lads in the cells across the wing—Perko, Waitane—celled up together, seemed to know each other from before. They'd noticed I had cigarettes in the yard.

Made their way over one afternoon.

"Can we get some tobacco, bro?"

I didn't give them the time of day at first. Mostly a race thing back then—that's just how it was, how I operated, who I was at that point in my life.

They were willing to trade. Offered matchsticks, glue, sandpaper.

I laughed.

"What the fuck would I want that for?"

Turns out those are valuable commodities inside. Things to do while you're locked down twenty hours a day. You can build things. Pass time. Keep your hands busy and your mind from eating itself.

I didn't take the trade. But I understood it better after that.

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There was a young guy in the cell next to mine.

Maybe nineteen. Prospecting for Black Power—one of the gangs that runs through the system like a current. Cocky little fucker. Thought he was harder than he was because he had patches to chase.

A few days in a row, I got woken up early by his music thumping through the wall.

Rap. Loud. Before unlock.

When we got let out one morning, I stopped by his cell on the way to breakfast.

"Hey. Can you keep it down until unlock? Waking me up early, bro."

He didn't take kindly to that.

A whiteboy telling him what to do—that's how he heard it. Didn't matter that I was asking, not telling. Didn't matter that I'd been respectful about it. He heard disrespect, and in his world, disrespect requires response.

I told him I wasn't telling him what to do. I was asking him to be respectful of others since we all had to live here.

Didn't matter.

One of the older Black Power members had seen me at his cell. Asked what was going on. Whatever the prospect told him, the instruction came back clear: handle it correctly, or be seen as weak.

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I picked up my breakfast and went back to my cell.

Sat down at the small desk. Started eating my toast. Cup of tea steaming next to me. Cellmate on his bunk, doing what he always did—existing as quietly as possible.

The prospect walked in.

Mid-bite, he clocked me right in the mouth.

Split my lip. I dropped the toast. Spilled my tea. Knocked my other piece of toast off the desk onto the floor.

So now I was pissed.

Not because he'd hit me. I'd been hit before. I'd be hit again.

Because I no longer had any breakfast. And he'd come into my house to do it.

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Some guys outside the cell pulled the door shut.

Keeping watch. Giving us space to figure things out. That's how it works—you don't interfere, you just make sure no one else does either.

I didn't know this kid beyond that morning's interaction. He wasn't the type of person I would have associated with at that point in my life, given what I stood for.

But I was confident in myself. And I definitely wasn't afraid of a bare-knuckle fight.

So that's what he got.

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Two minutes.

Maybe less.

When it was over, he had a black eye. His nose was bleeding. Split lip to match the one he'd given me.

I wasn't any worse off than when he'd walked in. Just a gash on my knuckles from his front teeth.

The door opened.

I threw him out.

There was a brief look from the others—assessing my condition, confirming the outcome. But that was it. In prison, once it's finished, it's considered sorted. No retaliation required unless the attack was unprovoked.

This wasn't unprovoked. Not by the logic of the place.

He'd been sent to establish dominance. It hadn't worked out that way.

That was between him and his patch now. Nothing to do with me anymore.

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My cellmate was shell-shocked.

He'd watched the whole thing from three feet away. The sudden escalation. The violence. The blood.

It didn't help with his unease about his current situation, put it that way.

But he wasn't affected ultimately. Just another thing for him to process in a place that made no sense to him.

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After that, I started doing yard time with one of the boys.

We'd run laps. Talk shit. Pass the time.

Found out I had a mate in general population—someone from the outside who'd landed before me. So I was keen to get moved over there, to where he was.

The kid next door kept his music down until unlock after that.

Whether it was because of the fight or something else, I never found out.

Problem solved either way.

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GENERAL POPULATION

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Moving to the main wing meant more freedom.

More yard time. More hours unlocked. The system's way of saying *you can handle yourself, so we don't need to watch you as closely*.

New schedule:

Unlock at 0630. Showers, then off to the dining hall for breakfast by 0730. Back to the wing at 0830. Back to cells at 0900.

Lunch in your cell.

Yard from 1300 to 1500, then back to cells.

Dining hall for dinner at 1700. Back to the wing for rec time at 1730. Cells at 1830 until morning.

More movement. More interaction. More opportunity for things to go sideways.

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They moved me with my classification celly at first.

I did not want this.

He was weak. Getting stood over for a pouch of tobacco every week—someone had figured out he wouldn't fight back, and now it was just a regular tax on his existence.

I couldn't be associated with that.

But there was a spare bunk in my mate Ivian's cell. And a TV. So I got myself moved to his house instead.

Problem solved.

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I also knew the kingpin.

The most senior inmate in that wing. In for arson and attempted murder—not the kind of person I would consider associating with now, at this point in my life. But back then, it was normal. That was the world I moved in.

Knowing him helped. To some degree.

It would help more later down the track.

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General population had its moments.

A couple that came close to serious problems. One that might have been life-threatening if it had been carried out.

There was a guy named Jay.

About five foot tall. Built like a fucking bulldozer—the kind of compact muscle that comes from years of violence and nothing else to do.

I had no idea who he was on the outside. Just seemed like a cocky fuckwit, really. Māori fella. Moved through the wing like he owned it.

I would later find out the story.

Jay had wanted to join Mongrel Mob—one of the most feared gangs in New Zealand. Prospected for them. Did what prospects do.

Then decided they were weak.

Not hard enough for what he'd built them up to be in his head. So he started his own gang instead.

Let that sink in.

This was a man who looked at Mongrel Mob and said *I can do better*.

Not someone to cross paths with in the wrong way.

But that's exactly what I did.